



HOME TRUTHS

India gets maximum space in Naipaul's new book as the Nobel Laureate takes on historic icons and lambasts contemporary Indian writing in English

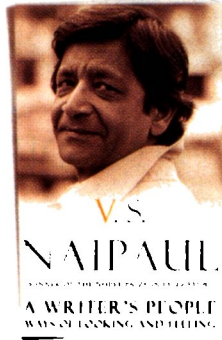
For V.S. Naipaul, in his own words "a serious traveller", there has never been a vantage point. "All my life I have had to think about ways of looking and how they alter the configuration of the world." His 29th book—his 15th in non-fiction—is all about multiple degrees of perception. *A Writer's People: Ways of Looking and Feeling*, an essay in five parts, is also an elaborate memorial service, and the characters who inhabit its pages are ancestral, historical or cultural in their importance. The people who concentrate the mind of Naipaul in this book are his father Seepersad Naipaul, Derek Walcott, the English writer Anthony Powell who at one time was the writer's friend and mentor in London, the French master Gustave Flaubert, and, most overwhelmingly, Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, Vinoba Bhave ("a foolish man" who attempted a Gandhi repeat), Nirad Chaudhury ("a small man", physically as well as intellectually), and those nameless Indian novelists who can't get hold of India, which continues to lie orphaned outside their narratives conditioned by the aesthetics of creative writing schools. India gets maximum space.

In the first part, he charts the career of two writers from the island of his birth—the successful Walcott who tapped the spiritual emptiness of the place and gave a "racial twist" to its unhappiness; and his father, a failure. "There was no tradition of Indian writing or colonial writing into which my

father might have been received. All the pain of his early life, the material that in another society might have been his making as a writer, remained locked away." Naipaul, in the end, finds poignancy in the failure of his father, and a kind of "falsified" craft in the triumph of Walcott, who would become the role model muse of the Caribbean who stayed back—unlike Naipaul. In the chapter "An English Way of Looking", Naipaul relives his formative years as a writer, and the victim here is Powell, a collector of people, and a novelist who couldn't rise above his Englishness. Powell in failure as a writer was, though in a different cultural context, like Naipaul pere.

The most engaging parts are the Indian chapters in which icons are blasted, and not always gently. Looking and not seeing—that is the Indian way. At one stage even Nehru was a victim of this way of looking at the world. In his autobiography, he has little to report about London or Harrow or Cambridge. "In Nehru's account, these places are just their names." And the best of Gandhi was not made in India. "There is little understanding that Gandhi had been created by his cultural incompetence of his three years in London and then by his embattled twenty years in South Africa." So India continues to experiment with its own versions of the Mahatma, without really knowing the original. Naipaul's "people" are in no position to write back. The backlash has to be from the living. Then, Sir Vidya never writes to please.

by S. Prasannarajan



EXCERPTS

THE MAHATMA AND AFTER

Wgo back to India, to the town of Kanpur, to the Indian National Congress conference of 1925. The conference tent was very big. It was more than a hundred yards long and sixty yards wide, and there were seven or eight thousand people sitting on matting on the ground. At the far end was the raised rostrum for speakers and distinguished visitors; they too were sitting on matting.

The fifty-six-year-old mahatma was there, in his strange garb: the tightly tied dhoti, like a diaper, around his waist and

upper legs, with a shawl (a concession to the Kanpur winter) over his shoulders. The writer Aldous Huxley, only thirty-one, also on the rostrum (at one session 'all but dead of fatigue' after sitting on the floor for six hours), was a witness of the occasion. He mentions the dhoti and the shawl, but he doesn't comment on them; he seems to take them on trust as the scant clothing to be expected of an Indian saint. He doesn't know (he seems to have begun reading Gandhi's autobiography only later) that that excessive simplicity of dress was Gandhi's own idea and would at first have been strange, perhaps outlandish,